

The New Fashion Victims

Remember 1994? That vintage year for beauty when a dusky Rs 5,000-a-show struggling Delhi model surprised the bookies and walked away, first with the Miss India title and then, incredibly enough, with the Miss Universe crown. Then a green-eyed model matched the first triumph by picking up the Miss World title. When Sushmita Sen and Aishwarya Rai were international beauty queens, when models became modern icons virtually overnight, when professionalism and international standards became buzz words, and when veteran model Shyamolie Verma declared, echoing several of her genetically blessed colleagues: "We've got global standing. Now it is up, up, up." Not quite. More than four years after the historical double victory, the gift has worn off. Modelling in India is swamped by wannabes but unable to produce a superstar, marred by excessive hype and hit by rabid competition and recession.

Priya Ramani, March 29, 1999, INDIA TODAY

DP: Perhaps there were fewer opportunities then. But today there are enough ramp shows, print and television campaigns for a model and then there are movies.

Despite the absence of professional make-up artists, do you feel the industry churned out some of the best talent between the '70s and '90s?

AB: We learnt everything on the job. I used to carry my own kit, down to a safety pin. The shows we did earlier were for textile companies, designers came in later. It was tough and I used to plan my hairstyle changes and colour coordination for every ramp entry myself.

MJR: We did everything on our own, provided our own inputs and improvised at every level.

DP: Everything evolves with time. The job of the make-up artists and hair stylists today is more about creating a certain look.

Do you feel you had a tough time?

AB: Models have it easy now. They literally get out from the bed, go for the shoot where almost everything, down to their nail polish, is planned for



Photograph by SHRIYA PATIL. Make-up and hair: Audrey Faria. Location: Courtesy, Drive bar & kitchen

BODIES BEAUTIFUL: Penty (left) and Sheikh

them. We read magazines and books, watched others and picked up the nuances along the way. I was paid Rs 350 for the Sunsilk campaign and Rs 500 for ramp shows thereafter. The Vimal campaigns paid me Rs 1,000, and I said to myself, "Wow, they have upped the stakes".

MJR: Yes times were tough, but I loved it. Monetary benefits never mattered and I have worked free of cost innumerable times. When I started in 1986, I was paid Rs 1,500 for shows and by the time I called it a day in 1993, Rs 3,000-3,500.

In which direction have agencies and image consultants propelled the industry?

AB: The industry as a whole is being monitored and models are taken care of pretty well—you don't have to fight for your rights.

MJR: I think agencies are a good thing only if there is homogeneity. If 40 per cent of the models are part of an agency while others are not, payment structures get distorted. In 1993, I had started an agency—Face 1, in collaboration with London-based Models 1 but it was ahead of its time. ■